

FORNAX

THE FURNACE

FOUND SOUTH OF CETUS, THIS CONSTELLATION'S PATTERN IS A WIDE "V" SHAPE LINKING THREE STARS. IT IS KNOWN FOR THE FORNAX CLUSTER OF GALAXIES, AND AS ONE OF OUR DEEPEST VIEWS INTO THE UNIVERSE.

Originally Fornax Chemica, the chemist's furnace, Fornax is one of 14 constellations devised by Frenchman Nicolas Louis de Lacaille after surveying the southern sky, in 1751–52. It is home to the Fornax Cluster, a rich cluster of galaxies 62 million light-years away. The brighter members of the 58-strong cluster can be seen with amateur equipment. The elliptical galaxy NGC 1316 (also called Fornax A) is the brightest, and also one of the strongest radio sources in the sky. Barred spiral NGC 1365 is the largest spiral galaxy of the cluster. A tiny region in the north of Fornax was specially imaged by the Hubble Space Telescope. Known as the Hubble Ultra Deep Field, the image contains 10,000 galaxies and is one of our deepest views of the Universe.



△ NGC 1097
The large Seyfert galaxy NGC 1097 is magnitude 10.3 and one of the sky's brightest barred spirals. It is interacting with the tiny elliptical galaxy NGC 1097A at top right. This is not the first small galaxy to be affected by NGC 1097; it engulfed a dwarf galaxy a few billion years ago.



△ NGC 1350
The arms in the inner region of this spiral galaxy form a complete ring, resembling a huge eye in space. The blue tint of the outer arms indicates active star formation. Other galaxies are visible through the outer parts. NGC 1350 is about 85 million light years away and 130,000 light-years across.

KEY DATA

Size ranking 41

Brightest stars Alpha (α)
3.9, Beta (β) 4.5

Genitive Fornacis

Abbreviation For

Highest in sky at 10pm
November–December

Fully visible 50°N–90°S



CHART 3

MAIN STARS

Alpha (α) Fornacis
Binary star

☼ 3.9 ↔ 46 light-years

Beta (β) Fornacis
Yellow giant

☼ 4.5 ↔ 169 light-years

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

NGC 1097

Barred spiral galaxy, also classed as a Seyfert galaxy

NGC 1316 (Fornax A)

Radio source and elliptical galaxy

NGC 1350

Spiral galaxy

NGC 1365

Barred spiral galaxy

NGC 1398

Barred spiral galaxy

IC 335

Lenticular galaxy

Alpha (α) Fornacis
A yellow binary star of magnitude 3.9, visible with a small telescope; it has a 6.9 magnitude orange companion orbiting it every 300 years

NGC 1316
Also known as Fornax A, this giant elliptical galaxy is a radio source about 60 million light-years away. It was formed by engulfing several smaller galaxies

Beta (β) Fornacis
A yellow giant about 11 times the size of the Sun and the second brightest in the constellation

